



SATISH SAXENA

LUCKNOW | Heartland Battle

It's a no-holds barred battle between Chief Minister Mayawati and the Congress leadership in Delhi. At stake is the crucial Dalit vote as Rahul Gandhi works to dethrone Mayawati for the title of messiah of the backward classes. The Rita Bahuguna-Joshi episode has revealed just how ugly this battle can get. Reacting to the unpalatable remarks hurled at her by the UPCC president on July 15, Mayawati wasted no time in putting Joshi behind bars. Then, after the brimstone, the fire: even as the police looked on, Joshi's Lucknow bungalow was set ablaze and looted, allegedly by BSP workers. Gandhi Jr rushed to Amethi where he condemned Joshi's remarks while supporting her sentiments against the state Government. Mayawati turned Joshi's insensitive and almost misogynistic comments into an anti-Dalit tirade, slapping a case against her under the provisions of the SC/ST (Prevention of Atrocities) Act. An aghast Congress distanced itself from her comments. Mayawati rubbed the Congress the wrong way, elevating M.M. Intezar Abdi, one of the accused for the arson at Joshi's home, to the status of minister of state. This is not the first face-off between Maya and the Congress. When Sonia recently threatened to go to jail if the rail coach factory at Rae Bareilly was not cleared, Mayawati retorted that she would "make arrangements to send her to prison". Surely, this fight is not one to finish anytime soon. *by Subhash Mishra*

**JOSHI AFTER
HER ARREST IN
MORADABAD**

150

criminal cases were lodged by Mayawati against Mulayam in 24 hours during her previous regime. She is not new to taking police action against opponents.